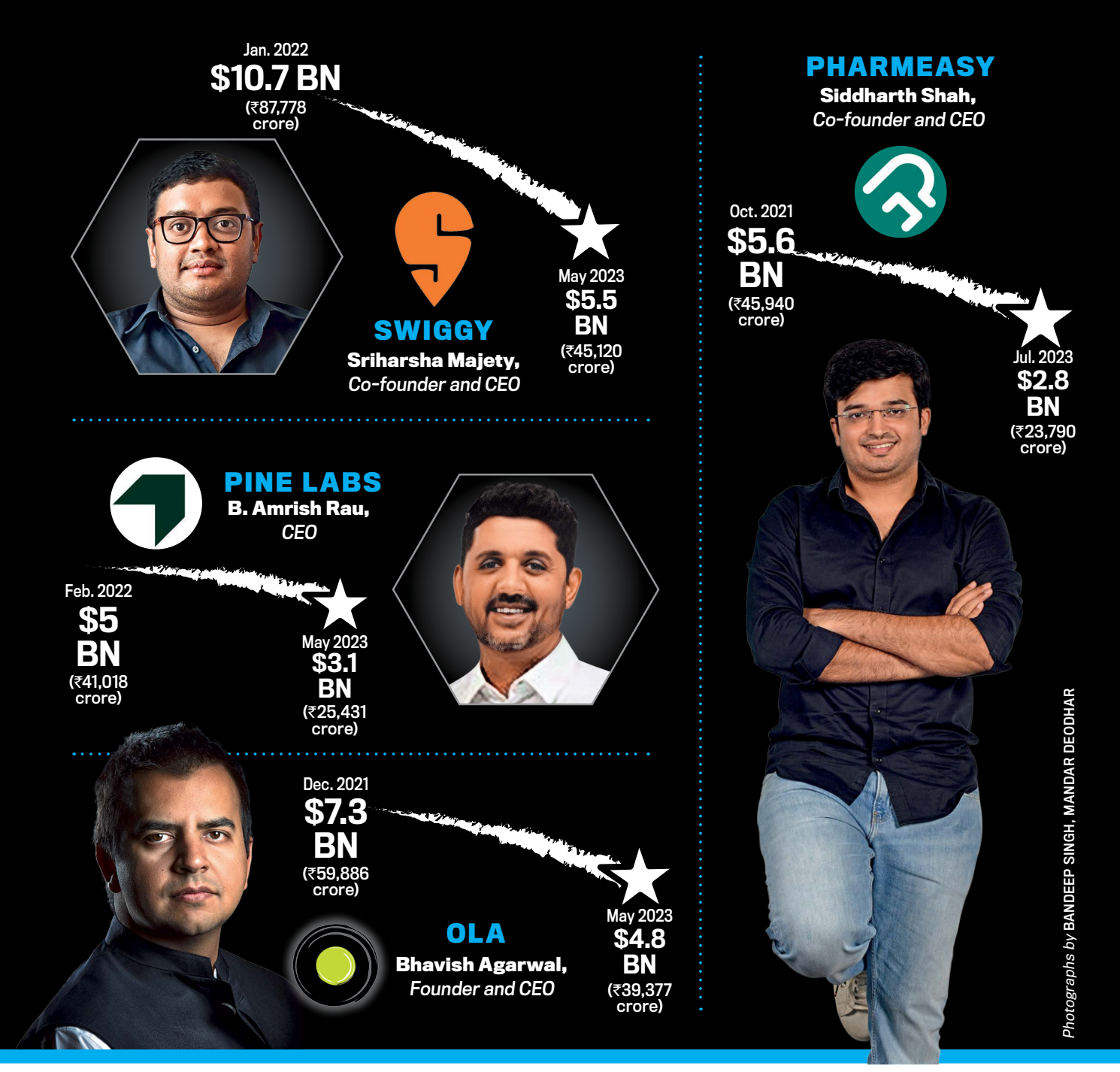


*Peak valuation #Valuation after mark-down by investors, according to media reports (2023)

84,012

No. of 'recognised' start-ups in India as on November 2022, per Centre's claim, compared to 452 in 2016

$3.8 bn

or Rs 31,179 crore, the funds raised by Indian start-ups in the first half of calendar year 2023, a 36% drop from the same period in 2022, and the lowest in four years

A double whammy—slowing revenues and no clear path to profitability on the one side, and a funds squeeze on the other—has put Indian start-ups under enormous pressure. It has left them with no option but to lay off staff and cut unwanted expenses to keeps their heads above water. Agencies that track the start-up sector say 88 start-ups laid off over 25,000 staff in the first three months of 2023 alone. This includes unicorns—start-ups with valuations of $1 billion [Rs 8,200 crore] or more—such as Byju's, Cars24, Dunzo, Ola, OYO, Meesho, Unacademy and Vedantu, says Inc42, a tech media platform (see *Start-up Layoffs*). The edtech segment holds the worst record, with 19 start-ups laying off more than 9,000 employees. Last year, Byju's, a decacorn then (a firm with over $10 billion or Rs 82,000 crore in valua-